

FOR OWNERS

2026 · W29

SEWANG

SEWANG SANGSA

It wasn't the economy What makes a bar thrive

A 2026 dining-market diagnosis for owners
— how what customers want has changed

The real data

The market split

Survival strategy

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TO OUR OWNERS

**The economy was
always tough.
What changed isn't
the economy —
it's the bar
customers want.**

Closures are at a record high — true. Yet
on the same street, **some places still
have a line.**

This issue covers, in order: ① the cold
data, ② how the market is splitting, and ③
what you can change because of it.

PART 1

The cold reality

By the numbers, not by feel — where the dining market stands now

The 1-million-closure era

Nationwide business closures — past 1 million for the first time on record

1.008_M

Nationwide closures, 2024

Closure rate ~9% for two straight years ·
food service alone: 153,000 closures

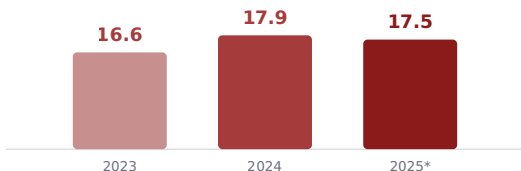
By sector

Closures cluster in domestic-demand-sensitive sectors — **food service and retail run about 2× the overall average.**

1 in 6 dining businesses shuts down

Nationwide dining closure rate — now higher than during COVID

Dining closure rate (%)



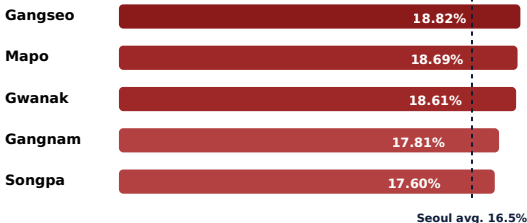
* Jan-May 2025, provisional

On the ground

70.9% of closures cite "weak sales / falling profitability." Delivery expansion plus fixed costs (rent, labor) squeeze margins.

Seoul: 1 in 5

Top districts by dining closure rate, Jan-May 2025 (Seoul avg. 16.5%)

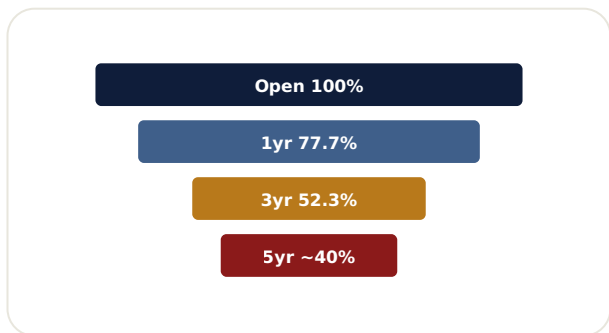


Flip it around

Even 'unbeatable Gangnam' is no exception. The prime districts carry the biggest **rent and labor risk**.

Of 10 openings, only 4 last 5 years

Survival rate, Seoul top-100 everyday
trades



What it means

Opening isn't the hard part — **staying open is**. Half are gone within 3 years.

PART 2

The market is splitting

It's not 'everyone's dying.' Winners and losers are separating — here's the line

The rising signboards are a set list

Brands that added the most stores in H1 (openings + conversions)

Norang Tongdak		+42
Jadam Chicken		+41
BBQ		+39
Mexicana		+35

What they share

Chicken and value brands lead — **low investment, delivery, fast turnover, easy prices.** The tougher the economy, the more customers move to 'a light, easy drink.'

The survivors pivoted this way

74 places that changed signs instead of closing — the direction is the customer taste

Bboggaeul Snacks	→	BBQ
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Crescent Dessert Cafe	→	Goobne Chicken
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Ppalgan Dak	→	Pocha Jungmun
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Chojangjip (Jangan)	→	Hansin Pocha
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Shrimp Chef (Seorak)	→	Uirak
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The direction

Independent snack shops, cafes and bars move toward **pocha, chicken and casual brands**. A 'pocha vibe' plus 'low price and turnover' is the format customers want now.

It's concept, not the economy

Same industry, diverging paths — opening rate vs. closing rate

**Franchise (proven concept) net
+6.6%p**

Open  **21.5%**

Close  **14.9%**

**All incl. independents net decline
(opens < closes)**

Youth-run eateries, 1yr · per 100 openings

New  **100**

Closed  **127.5**

Closure rate by type

Korean 19% > bars 14.2% > pizza 13.1% > chicken 12.1%. **Whether the concept fits customer taste** decides who survives.

PART 3

So how do you survive?

Applying where the data points to your
own store

This is the store customers go to now

Tying 40,000 SNS needs to what rising trades share

1 A cold first glass

Draft beer and highballs. The first-glass refreshment is the reason to visit

2 Easy prices

Value, cost-efficiency, fast turnover. A 'come often, come light' structure

3 A relaxed pocha vibe

Casual and hip over formal. Easy for solo drinks or small groups

4 Variety and signatures

Flavored highballs, crafted draft (matcha, ube Sapporo)

5 Photo-worthy looks

Your store — how many apply?

Fewer than 3 below is a sign to review your concept

- ☐ **Cold draft and highballs** stand out as first-class menu
- ☐ Value **snack sets** drive repeat visits
- ☐ Interior and service are **relaxed and casual** (no formality)
- ☐ You have a **signature glass** (flavored or crafted draft)
- ☐ Menu and glassware come out **photo-ready**

Sewang helps

From signature draft recipes and summer order plans to new-product stocking — **your rep helps plan the concept renewal with you.**

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CLOSING

Before blaming the economy, look again at the customer.

Downturns have always existed — and thriving stores have too. The difference is **whether you matched what customers want now.** Sewang will prepare your next move together, with data and supply.

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Data: H1 analysis of 29 franchises from public licensing records (2026-01-01→06-22) · closure/turnover rates from NTS, KFTC franchise data, and industry tallies (2024–2025) · consumer needs via SNS analysis (Sometrend). For directional reference.